ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

Academic Writing and Referencing: Say It Clearly, Cite It Properly

Structure, argument and citations for assignments that would otherwise lose marks

STUDY SKILLS

Study Skills

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Marks are lost for the same reasons every semester: no clear argument, weak structure, quotation without citation and padding. This pack covers essay structure, paragraph logic, APA-style citation, paraphrasing and proofreading.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Plan and structure an academic essay with a clear thesis.
- Write paragraphs that make one point and support it with evidence.
- Cite sources correctly in APA style and paraphrase without plagiarising.
- Proofread for clarity, grammar and consistency.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Structure before style

An academic assignment answers a question with a reasoned argument.

- Introduction: context, the question, your thesis and the route of the essay.
- Body: one point per paragraph, each supported by evidence and explanation.
- Conclusion: restate the answer, not new arguments.
- Use headings when the assignment is long and permits them.
- Define key terms early, especially contested ones.
- Aim for clarity over impressive vocabulary.

> **The thesis test**
> Read your introduction alone. Can a stranger state your position? If not, your thesis is not yet doing its job.

Citation and plagiarism

Referencing is not decoration; it lets a reader verify your evidence and distinguishes your ideas from others'.

- In-text citation, APA style: (Author, Year) or Author (Year).
- Reference list entries: author, year, title, source and access details where required.
- Cite page numbers for direct quotations.
- Paraphrase by understanding, closing the source and writing in your own structure.
- Copying without citation is plagiarism, whether or not you intended it.
- Keep a working reference list while writing, not after.

Editing and proofreading

Editing is where average drafts become good assignments.

1. Put the draft aside for a few hours before editing.
2. Check that every paragraph has one clear point.
3. Read aloud to catch awkward or run-on sentences.
4. Verify every citation and reference entry.
5. Check formatting, font, spacing and word count.
6. Get one reader to explain your argument back to you.

> **Common killers**
> No clear thesis, unsupported claims, long quotations doing the thinking, and references that do not match in-text citations.

The essay is an argument with a shape

Academic writing exists to make and support a claim. The introduction states the question, the position and the route; body paragraphs each make one claim and support it; the conclusion states what has been established and what remains open. Everything else - background, definitions, context - serves that structure.

The most common weakness is a paragraph that reports rather than argues. If a paragraph could be replaced by a list of facts, it is not doing argumentative work. The fix is a topic sentence that makes a claim, followed by evidence, followed by a sentence explaining what the evidence shows.

Academic register is precise rather than ornate. Prefer the specific to the general, the active to the passive where the agent matters, and the short word to the long one. "The policy reduced enrolment in rural areas" is stronger than "the implementation of the aforementioned policy resulted in a diminution of enrolment within rural localities".

Citation, quotation and avoiding plagiarism

Citation does two jobs: it lets a reader check your evidence, and it distinguishes your contribution from other people's. Any idea, fact or phrase taken from a source needs a reference, whether quoted, paraphrased or summarised.

Quotations should be used sparingly and for a reason - because the wording matters, because you are invoking authority, or because you intend to disagree precisely. Always introduce a quotation, then analyse it. A quotation dropped into a sentence without comment is a gap in the argument.

Plagiarism includes copying, paraphrasing without citation, reusing your own previous work without acknowledgement, and submitting work written by someone else. The procedural defence is simple: take notes with page numbers at the time of reading, keep a running source list, and draft from notes rather than from open books.

> **Cite as you write**
> Adding references at the end is how citations get lost. Put the reference in the sentence as you draft; tidying the format later is easy, reconstructing the source is not.

Style, format and revision

Learn one citation style properly - MLA, APA or Harvard as your department requires - and apply it consistently. Consistency matters more than which style, but inconsistency signals carelessness.

Structure the document: title page, introduction, headed sections, conclusion, reference list, appendices if required. Follow the word limit exactly; exceeding it is usually penalised. Use readable spacing and a consistent font.

Revise in passes rather than all at once: one pass for argument and structure, one for paragraph logic, one for sentence clarity, one for citation and mechanics. Reading aloud catches errors that silent reading hides. If possible, ask someone to read only the introduction and tell you what the essay argues - if they cannot, the introduction needs work.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Rebuilding a reporting paragraph

"Nigeria has many universities. Enrolment has increased. Funding has not increased. This has caused problems."

1. Identify the missing claim: what do these facts together show?
2. Draft a topic sentence making that claim.
3. Combine the facts into one or two sentences of evidence.
4. Add a sentence explaining the mechanism or consequence.
5. Cite the source of the enrolment and funding figures.
6. Result: a paragraph with a claim, evidence, explanation and reference.

> **What to carry forward**
> Facts do not argue. State what they show, then show it.

2. Integrating a quotation

You want to use a critic's statement that the novel "refuses the comfort of resolution".

1. Introduce the source and the context of the claim.
2. Quote exactly, in quotation marks, with a page reference.
3. Explain what the phrase means in relation to the text.
4. Connect it to your own argument - agree, qualify or disagree.
5. Keep the quotation short enough that your analysis is longer than the quote.

> **What to carry forward**
> Introduce, quote, explain, connect. Four moves for every quotation.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Explain what constitutes plagiarism and how to avoid it procedurally.

15 marks

1. Define plagiarism, including paraphrase and self-reuse.
2. Explain why citation alone does not make use legitimate - analysis is still required.
3. Describe the procedural defence: notes with pages, running source list, drafting from notes.
4. Note institutional consequences.

Q2. Describe the structure of an argumentative essay.

15 marks

1. Introduction: question, position, route.
2. Body: one claim per paragraph, with evidence and explanation.
3. Counter-argument and reply.
4. Conclusion: what is established and what remains open.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Thesis statement. The central claim an essay sets out to establish.

Topic sentence. The sentence stating a paragraph's claim.

Paraphrase. Restating a source's specific passage in your own words.

Plagiarism. Presenting another's words, structure or work as your own.

In-text citation. A brief reference in the body pointing to a full source entry.

Reference list. Full details of every source cited, in the required style.

Academic register. Formal, precise language suited to scholarly argument.

Cohesion. The linking of sentences and paragraphs into a coherent whole.

Counter-argument. The strongest case against your claim, which you must answer.

Word limit. The permitted length, usually enforced with a penalty.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Argument

Claims.

- Write a thesis for two questions.
- Draft one paragraph with claim, evidence, explanation.
- Identify reporting sentences in old work.

Week 2 - Sources

Citation.

- Practise paraphrasing without copying structure.
- Build a reference list in the required style.
- Integrate one quotation with analysis.

Week 3 - Draft

Structure.

- Write a full draft to the word limit.
- Check each paragraph's claim.
- Add counter-argument and reply.

Week 4 - Revise

Clarity.

- Revise in four separate passes.
- Read aloud for sentence errors.
- Check every citation against the source.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Your department's citation style guide.
- A guide to academic writing for undergraduates.
- Your institution's plagiarism policy.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. What is the function of a thesis statement?

Answer: It states the central claim the essay will defend, giving the reader a clear position to follow.

2. How do you paraphrase without plagiarising?

Answer: Understand the passage, close the source, rewrite the idea in your own words and structure, then cite the source.

3. Write an APA in-text citation for a 2021 book by Ada Obi.

Answer: (Obi, 2021) or Obi (2021) if used as part of the sentence.

4. Why is a long quotation a weakness unless analysed?

Answer: It replaces your reasoning with someone else's words; marks are earned by analysing the evidence.

5. Name three proofreading checks.

Answer: Paragraph focus, sentence clarity and citation accuracy. Formatting and word count also count.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write a thesis statement for one assignment question.
- [ ] Outline three body paragraphs with evidence for each.
- [ ] Draft a 500-word essay and self-edit it twice.
- [ ] Build a reference list in APA style with five sources.
- [ ] Practise paraphrasing one paragraph and compare with the original.
- [ ] Read your draft aloud and mark every sentence that stumbles.
- [ ] Ask a coursemate to summarise your argument from the draft.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date: